



The Magic Cupcake Effect

A new device and an upgraded operating system... is that enough for Android to finally make its presence felt in a highly competitive mobile phone market?

*T*he first phone bearing Google's open source mobile operating system, the HTC G1, might have sold more than a million units, but it did not trigger the open source mobile OS revolution that many had expected. It did get decent reviews but was seen by many as a work in progress with a number of rough edges. Be patient, we were told, this is not the best of Android. Better things are in store.

So it was hardly surprising that many mobile phone lovers were disappointed at the relative absence of devices based on Android at the 2009 Mobile World Congress. That said, the one Android-powered handset that was launched, did grab more than its share of headlines—the HTC Magic. And May saw the device being released in the markets (alas, not in India, although our sources tell us that it will make its way here, unlike the G1), along with a significant update to the original Android operating system. The

update, called Cupcake, took the operating system to 1.5 and added a number of features to the original operating system. But the question running through everyone's minds was: were these enhancements enough to make the new device a mainstream success?

Serving a slice of (cup)cake...

It speaks volumes of just how much Google has changed the mobile operating system game that people have actually become more interested in the OS running on the device than the device itself. The Cupcake update has ironed out a number of the faults of the original Android, although there is no visible change in the interface itself. Perhaps the most spectacular change in the OS is the inclusion of an on-screen keyboard—the first edition had none, forcing users of the G1 to slide out the QWERTY even for the most minor typing task. The new keyboard seems impressive and works in both landscape and portrait